

Erectile Dysfunction (ED)

Patient Information · A common, treatable problem and a heart-health signal

WARWIKI

Erectile dysfunction (ED) means trouble getting or keeping an erection firm enough for sex. It is very common, and it becomes more common with age. It can be treated. Erections depend on healthy blood flow, so ED can also be an **early warning sign** of heart and blood vessel disease.

What Causes It

Erections need healthy blood vessels, nerves and hormones, and a calm mind. ED often has more than one cause:

- **Blood flow.** This shares risk factors with heart disease: diabetes, high blood pressure, high cholesterol, smoking and extra weight.
- **Nerves.** Damage after prostate or pelvic surgery or radiation, or from diabetes, a spinal cord injury or multiple sclerosis.
- **Hormones.** For example, low testosterone.
- **Medicines and mood.** Some blood pressure and depression medicines, plus stress, worry, depression or relationship strain.

A Heart-Health Check

The small arteries of the penis can show trouble before the heart does. New ED is a good reason to check your blood pressure, blood sugar and cholesterol. Treating these helps your heart and may help your erections.

How It Is Checked

- Questions about your health, medicines and sex life, and an exam
- Blood tests for sugar, cholesterol and a morning testosterone level

Learn the Terms

Erectile dysfunction (ED)

Trouble getting or keeping an erection firm enough for sex.

Vascular

About blood flow. Poor blood flow is a common cause of ED.

PDE5 inhibitor

The usual first ED pills, such as sildenafil or tadalafil.

Vacuum device

A tube and pump that pull blood into the penis to make it firm.

Penile injection

A shot you give yourself in the side of the penis to cause an erection.

Penile implant

A device placed in the penis by surgery.

Testosterone

The main male hormone.

Can it be treated? Yes. There are good options at every stage, from pills to devices to surgery. Many men start with the simplest option, but you can choose any treatment that is safe for you after talking with your team.

How It Is Treated

- 1 Healthy habits.** Exercise, a healthy diet, weight loss, not smoking, and good control of diabetes and blood pressure help your health and may help erections. Your team may also review your medicines.
- 2 Pills (PDE5 inhibitors).** The usual first treatment. They work with sexual stimulation. If they do not seem to work, ask your team about the dose and timing before giving up.
- 3 Penile injections or a vacuum device.** Good options if pills are not enough or not safe for you. Your first injection is a test done in the office.
- 4 Penile implant.** A reliable surgical option. Most men with an implant are satisfied.

Other help: counseling, alone or with a partner, helps with stress and worry. Testosterone alone does not treat ED. If blood tests confirm a low level, treating it may help pills work better. Shockwave therapy and stem cell or platelet (PRP) shots are not proven treatments.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- ED that started after an injury to the pelvis or penis
- Side effects from an ED treatment that worry you

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have chest pain or trouble breathing, during sex or at any time
- An erection on treatment lasts **more than 4 hours**
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- 1.** ED is common and can be treated, with options from pills to implants.
- 2.** It can be an early sign of heart disease, so get your heart health checked.
- 3.** Never take ED pills with nitrate heart medicines or "poppers".